Stye of the Eye

By Christopher Durang

CHARACTERS:
Jake / Dr. Martina Dysart, a psychiatrist
Ma, Jake's mother / Beth, Jake's wife

INTRODUCTION

Christopher Durang's "A Stye of the Eye" is theatrical caricature at its best. Those of you familiar with Sam Shepard (all five of you) will appreciate the blatant references to beat-you-over-the-head-with-it symbols, mostly notably from his play A Lie of the Mind. For those of you unfamiliar with Shepard's depictions of the lonesome prairie, untamed masculinity, and incest, the low humor of white trash will keep you entertained for the full twenty-three minutes and nine seconds. With some parody of David Mamet and whoever wrote Agnes of God in there to boot, "A Stye of the Eye" massacres pretentious plays, family values, and a baby lamb. Enjoy.

JAKE: Answer the phone damn it. Answer the phone. [Bangs the phone receiver on the side of the phone, or any other surface.] Come on, come on! [Into receiver.] Hello! Hello!

[Lights up on a different part of the stage. MA is discovered next to a phone, or enters calmly over to the ringing phone. MA is between forty and fifty, and dressed in a sloppy, comfortable print dress. Her hair is not fussed with, just pulled back out of her face. She is a no-nonsense woman, tough, matter-ot-fact, sounds like a Cracker.]

MA: Hello?
JAKE: Hey, Ma?
MA: Who is this?
JAKE: Ma, it's your son.
MA: Who?
JAKE: Your son, ma.
MA: I got two sons. Which one are you?
JAKE: I'm Jake.
MA: Jake?
JAKE: Jake!
MA: You're not the other one? What's his name?

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JAKE: Frankie. No, it's not Frankie, Ma. It'sJake.

MA: Jake?

JAKE: Stop saying Jake, or I'm going to come over to your house and punch you in the mouth.

MA: [Her voice warming, friendly.] Oh, now it sounds like Jake. How ar eyou, baby?

JAKE: She's real bad, Ma.

MA: Who, Jake?

JAKE: She's all red and blue and purple.

MA: Who you talkin' about, Jake?

JAKE: I had to hit her. She was dressin' real sexy like, and goin' off to rehearsal.

MA: Who is this you're talkin' about, Jake?

JAKE: It's Beth, Ma. My wife.

MA: Are you married, Jake?

JAKE: Ma, you know I am. You wuz at the wedding.

MA: Why didn't you marry your sister, Jake, she always liked you.

JAKE: That would be incest, Ma.

MA: No, it wouldn't. Incest would be if you married me. If you married your sister, it would be ... sorority.

JAKE: Shut up, Ma. I'm tryin' to tell you I killed Beth.

MA: Who's Beth?

[Note: MA's lapses in memory are complete. When she says something like "Who~ Beth," she has no recollection whatsoever that she heard the name Beth a few seconds before. So all her questions are asked innocently, trying her best to get information. There is no "what was that thing you said a moment ago" tone to any of her repeating questions. And thus when JAKE seems irritated with her forgetting, she has no idea what is the cause of his frustration.]

JAKE: She's my wife.

MA: I didn't know you were married.

JAKE: You have the attention span of a gnat. Ma, we've been through this. Beth is my wife, you wuz at the wedding, and I just killed her.

MA: [Suspicious.] Who is this calling me?

JAKE: It's your son, Ma! I just killed my wife.

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MA: Well, I never pay attention to the tramps you start up with. She probably asked for it.

JAKE: She was goin' to rehearsal, Ma. She's into actin', Ma, and she's goes off to fuckin' rehearsal, and every day she dresses more slutty like, and I just know that she's doin' it with some fuckin' actor on her lunch break. And I seen her in a play once. She stank. .

MA: [Upset.] Whatcha goin' to plays for, baby? I didn't bring you up to spend your time goin' to plays. You're gonna end up like that Sam Shepard boy down the road. Why don't you settle down and marry your sister?

JAKE: Stop talkin' about incest, Ma. I just killed my wife.

MA: Well, did anyone see you?

JAKE: No.

MA: Well, there, you see. Go get a good night's sleep, and in the morning we'll get you another one. Why don't you marry your sis ... Oh, that's right, you don't like that idea. You're stubborn like your father.

JAKE: I didn't want to kill her, Ma, but she asked for it.

MA: Who you talkin' about, baby?

JAKE: Beth, Beth! How many times do I have to say it!

MA: Thirty-three. I'm getting bored with this conversation, Jake. Is your good brother Frankie there?

JAKE: What?

MA: Put Frankie on.

MA: Frankie, is that you?

JAKE: Wait a minute, Ma.

MA: Did you hear what Jake told me?

JAKE: Hold your horses a minute, Ma. Hey, Frankie! Ma wants to speak to you! Frankie! [Changes personalities, and witches phone hands; sounds more polite and reasoned though still has a temper.] Hey, Mom, how are you?

MA: Oh, Frankie, I love it the way you call me "Mom" and Jake calls me "Ma." It's so differentiating. Frankie, did you hear that Jake killed his wife?

JAKE: He told me, Mom. He's a crazy, spoiled, mixed up kid. Mom, what are we gonna do about Jake?

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MA: Who?

JAKE: Jake.

MA: Jake's dead. His wife just killed him.

JAKE: You got it backwards, Ma. I mean "Mom."

MA: You know you and Jake sound so much alike that sometimes I think you're both two different aspects of the same personality. That means I gave birth to a symbol, and me with no college edjacation.

JAKE: I'm not a symbol, Ma. I'm a westerner looking for the big open expanses, but they're gettin' smaller and smaller. There's no place to hope, Ma.

MA: You sound like a symbol. But not some prissy Ivy League-type symbol. My children are virile, masculine symbols who carry guns and beat up women. You all got so much testosterone in you, that you got a native kinda poetry in you, even when you spit. Why don't you go kill a woman like your brother?

JAKE: But what woman is like my brother?

MA: That's not what I meant, stupid. The verb was implied in that sentence, as in "Why don't you go kill a woman like your brother did, " "did" in imaginary bracket signs. And me with no college edjacation. Put Jake back on the line, honey, I'm bored with this conversation. No, never mind, I got an idea. Why don't you go try to find Beth. Maybe she's not dead. Maybe she's only brain damaged, and you can marry her. That might have symbolic value of some sort.

JAKE: But what symbolic value would that have, Ma?

MA: I don't know, I'm not a writer. But if we put some jazz music under it, or some good country sounds, it's bound to mean somethin' to somebody. I gotta go now, Frankie, the cactus is whistHn' on the stove. But you keep an eye on your brother, and if you wanna marry your sister, just let me know. [Hangs up, exits; lights fade on her part of the stage.]

JAKE: Goodbye, Mom. [Switches to JAKE personality; grabs for phone from himself] Hey, I ain't done talkin' to her yet! [Switches back to Frankie, hangs up the phone.] Well, she's done talkin' to you. Why'd you go and kill her, Jake? [Switches to JAKE.] Ma? [Switches to Frankie, annoyed.] No, not Mom. Beth. [Switches to

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JAKE.] I don't know. She just kept goin' to all them rehearsals and ... well, it irritated me. [Switches to Frankie.] I can understand that. [Switches to JAKE; vehement.] Especially this one play called "Agnes is Odd" or some such thing, all about this flakey nun who killed her baby.

[Lights change. We see the play JAKE is remembering. JAKE plays the role of Dr. Martina Dysart] The sound of Stravinsky-like music, or Carmina Burana. Startling, mysterious, otherworldly.

Enter DR. MARTINA DYSART, in a crisp business suit, smoking three cigarettes, one in her mouth, two in her hands. She takes the one in her mouth out, and addresses the audience. She is intense and concerned, solving a deep mystery.]

DR. MARTINA: The baby was-discovered in a waste basket with the umbilical cord knotted around its neck. The mother was unconscious, next to the body. The mother was a young nun called Sister Agnes, Sister Agnes Dei. During the night she had given birth and then seemingly killed her baby. Then she went out to the convent stables and blinded eight horses with a metal crucifix. That much is fact. But she is also a musical genius along the lines of Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart. Furthermore, my life as a psychiatrist is drab and depressing, and even though I think it unappealing that she killed her baby and blinded the horses, still I envy her passion. You wouldn't see me getting up in the middle of the night to go down to the stables. And furthermore, I'm a lapsed Catholic who wishes I had her faith, and I wish I had a horse, and I ... wish I was a composer. In short, there are many ideas and subtleties to think about here, so stop rattling your programs and let's move on with it. My first meeting with Agnes, I thought she was brain damaged. [Enter SISTER AGNES, the sensitive nun. Dressed perhaps in the strange white nun ~ outfit Amanda Plummer wore in the Broadway version of ''Agnes of God, "which is the same design Sally Field wore in "The Flying Nun" tv series. Or a more conventional nun outfit is okay too.

JAKE's wife BETH is playing SISTER AGNES. Actress formerly playing "MA" plays the role of BETH"

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AGNES: Look, stigmata. [AGNES holds out her palms, which at first glance have gaping red holes in them. A second later one notices that she seems to be holding red rubber things in her palms, with reddish centers to them.]

DR. MARTINA: Nonsense, those are plastic Dr. Spock ears. Look, I'll show you. [D R. MARTINA removes the ''plastic stigmata" and puts the Dr. Spock ears on her ears. She leaves them there for the rest of the scene.] People sell these at Halloween. Do you like Halloween, Agnes?

AGNES: Pooh. Pooh.

DR. MARTINA: Pooh. Winnie the Pooh? Do you like Winnie the Pooh?

AGNES: Pooh. Pooh. Puer. [Last word is pronounced "Pooh-air. '1

DR. MARTINA: Puer. That's Latin for boy. Do you like boys, Agnes?

AGNES: Pooh-ella.

DR. MARTINA: Yes, puella. Latin for girl. Maybe it's Latin you like. Do you like Latin, Agnes? Hie, haec, hoc, and all that.

AGNES: Puer. Puella. Eck, eck, equus! [Momentarily mimes blinding horses, then pulls herself together again.]

DR. MARTINA: Boy, girl, horse. This isn't a very intelligent conversation, Agnes. Don't they make you speak sentences in the convent, Agnes?

AGNES: Agnes Dei.

DR. MARTINA: Yes, that's Latin for Lamb of God. [With a shock of recognition.] Oh my God, your name is Agnes Dei, isn't it? Good grief, I wonder if that means you're some sort of sacrificial lamb to God, and that maybe your giving birth was an immaculate conception, and that the father is God Himself!! Good Lord, what a shocking idea, oh my mind is running, let me try to breath deeply for a moment. [Puffs on several of her cigarettes.] Goodness, what dreadful rubbish I was just speaking. Rather like speaking in tongues. Do you like tongues, Agnes?

AGNES: We had tongue sandwiches at that convent, and it made all the Sisters menstruate.

DR. MARTINA: [Pause.] I think. that's rather an obscene remark you've just made, Agnes. Did you mean to be obscene?

AGNES: Children should be obscene. And not furred.

DR. MARTINA: Furred?

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AGNES: Furred like a bird.

DR. MARTINA: What is the matter with you exactly? Are you a saint or are you brain damaged?

AGNES: [Sings, lasciviously.]Erotic, erotic,
Put your hands all over my body!

DR. MARTINA: I see. Well, if you're going to sing, I think I'll go now. By the way, which member of the convent is it who won't let you watch MTV? [Shudders to herself] What a sharp remark of mine. I'm definitely in the right profession.

AGNES: No do with MTV.:

DR. MARTINA: Of course, it do. Does. That's the kind of song that's sung on MTV.:

AGNES: Noooooooo. Who sing, Doctor?

DR. MARTINA: I forget. That slutty woman who changes her look all the time, whats-her-name ... oh my God, her name is Madonna, which means "Mother of God!" [AGNES has a screaming fit at this scary coincidence, and falls to the ground rolling around in circles, going "Whoop! Whoop! Whooop!'1

AGNES: Whoop! Whoop! VVhoop! Whoop! Whoop!

[Lights back up on JAKE.]

JAKE: [As JAKE; explaining to Frankie.] It was after that terrible play that I took Beth out in the parking lot and I beat her to a pulp. "Your play was pretentious!" I said, and then I punched her. "You were unconvincing as a nun, and I didn't know whether you were supposed to be crazy or sane," and then I kicked her in the side. "And I don't like the previous play you wuz in, "The Reluctant Debutante," either, and then I took her head and I put it under the tire of the Chevrolet, and I dropped it on her. And that's how I killed her. [Switches to Frankie.] Oh, Jake. The play couldn't have been that bad. [Switches to JAKE.] It was. It was. I fuckin' hated it, man. It made me wanna puke. [Switches to Frankie.] Yeah, but to kill someone. [Switches to JAKE; big baby, teary.] Oh, Frankie, I miss her already. I wish she was alive so we could go on a second honeymoon together. [Switches to Frankie.] I got some land in Florida I could sell ya. [Switches to JAKE.] Oh

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yeah? [Switches to Frankie.] It's called Glen Gary Glen Ross. [Switches to JAKE.] Oh I don't want to go there. [Switches to Frankie, who now speaks in a fast, staccato rhythm, with a lot of aggressive salesman energy.] Why the fuck not? The place is good. Not great maybe, but what I'm sayin' is, it's good. Not great maybe, but good. That's what I'm sayin'. It may be swamp, it may have bugs, but fuck, Jake, what's perfect? You tell me. No, don't tell me, I'll tell you. It's not great, good. Am I right? Do you understand what I'm sayin'? Should I say it again? What I'm sayin' is, fuck shit piss damn, it ain't half bad. Half good, half bad. You gotta settle. It ain't perfect. Settle. Gatta. You gotta settle. A negotiation. Give and take. You know what I'm sayin'? What I'm sayin' is ... [Switches to JAKE, frustrated and angered by Frankie's irritating sales pitch.] Shut up! I know what you're saying, you sound life-like, granted, but you repeat yourself and you're monotonous, and you're ... insensitive to my upset about my wife. She is dead, you know. I deserve sympathy. [Switches to Frankie.] Yeah, but you killed her.

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